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Genesis 4: Cain, Abel, Free Will, and Moral Evil

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The story of Cain and Abel is one which has captured the interest of scholars, teachers, preachers, parents, children, and the like. It has often been depicted in art and media, and is usually one of the first stories children learn in Sunday School as they move through the Bible. Though it is important for children to know the stories, this one is not so child-friendly. It is the narrative of the first sin outside of the Garden of Eden and entails one man's sin against his brother. It is also an account which has something to say about the problem of evil, free will, and moral evil. Is Cain responsible for his actions? What role does God play in this pericope? The story of Cain and Abel is the story of man using his free will to execute the first moral evil found in the Bible.

Retelling the Story

Genesis 4 begins with Eve giving birth to Cain "with the help of the LORD."[1] There are different traditions for this phrase at the end of 4:1. The LXX has "διὰ τοῦ θεοῦ" ("through God"), the Vulgate has "per Deum" or "per Dominum" ("through God"), Targum Onkelos has "from before God," and the Peshitta has "to God."[2] However, probably the most compelling understanding is that the phrase is mistakenly preserved as אֶת־יְהוָה instead of תֶּת־יְהוָה.[3] If so, the end of the verse should read, "I have acquired a man *to give God*."[4] This would mean that Eve wanted to dedicate her son to God, which adds to the tragedy of the narrative. But no one knows for certain.

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[1] Gen. 4:1c. Unless otherwise stated, all Scripture is taken from the NEW AMERICAN STANDARD BIBLE®, Copyright © 1960, 1962, 1963, 1971, 1972, 1973, 1975, 1977, 1995 by The Lockman Foundation. Used by permission.

[2] Aron Pinker, "Naming of Cain in Genesis 4:1 and Its Consequence." *BBR* 27, no. 2 (2017): 157–68 (159-60). For discussion of modern exegesis, see pp. 160-63.

[3] So ibid., 163. Pinker suggests that when Hebrew evolved from paleo script to square script, there was a period of time when ת and א could be confused. I have colored these letters red above for clarity. For Pinker's discussion, see ibid., 163-68. Although, I find Pinker's conclusion concerning Cain's actions with connection to Gen. 4:1 less persuasive.

[4] So ibid., 165. Italics added. Pinker's reconstructed phrase: "וַתֹּאמֶר קָנִיתִי אִישׁ תֶּת־יְהוָה."

Interestingly, the narrative only offers the meaning of Cain's name and not Abel's; perhaps this is to emphasize Cain's role in the narrative over Abel's, since Cain is the main character of it.[5,6]

Next, Cain and Abel offer sacrifices to God.[7] Cain offers from "the fruit of the ground" while Abel offers "the firstlings of his flock and their fat portions."[8] The text then says that God regarded Abel's offering but not Cain's, resulting in Cain becoming "very angry and his countenance fell."[9] Why does the Genesis author not spell out precisely why Abel was accepted and Cain was not? Perhaps because that is not the point of the narrative.[10] What Cain does in response is the reason why the Genesis author is recording this event.[11] God comes to Cain and talks to him, saying that if he does well, he will be lifted up , but if he does not do well, "sin is crouching at the door; and its desire is for you [Cain], but you must master it."[12] McGuiggan writes, "God…knowing how crucial this moment is for the sinning man, tries to rally him for the fight of his young life."[13] Delitzsch sees a "divine warning which tries to bring him to reflection

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[5] A similar sentiment can be found in ibid., 166, "The reason for the naming of Cain must be assumed to play an important role in the story that follows."

[6] I am indebted to Claus Westermann, *Genesis 1-11: A Commentary*, trans. John J. Scullion, CC (Minneapolis: Augsburg, 1984), 285, for the observation that Abel is almost exclusively referred to as Cain's brother in the narrative. See Gen. 4:2, 8 (2x), 9 (2x), 10, and 11. Notice also: "His [Abel's] role is passive; he has nothing to say in the narrative. Only his blood cries out after he is murdered" (302).

[7] See Nathan Ward, *The Growth of the Seed: Notes on the Book of Genesis* (Chillicothe, OH: DeWard, 2007), 76. Ward suggests that because of how casually sacrificing is brought up in the narrative, this may not be the first instance of mankind offering sacrifices.

[8] Gen. 4:3.

[9] Gen. 4:4.

[10] The NT suggests that Cain's deeds were wicked (cf. 1 John 3:12). Hebrews 11:4 may imply something was wrong with Cain's heart in his offering (Abel "by faith" offered). Helpfully, Blessing O. Boloje, "Rethinking Violence through the Narrative of Genesis 4:1-16," *In die Skriflig / In Luce Verbi 55*, no. 1 (2021): 3: "This reversal motif – the preference of the younger son to the firstborn – is frequently and consistently found elsewhere in the Bible and, especially, in Genesis." For early exegesis, see John Byron, "Cain's Rejected Offering: Interpretive Approaches to a Theological Problem, *Journal for the Study of the Pseudepigrapha 18*, no. 1 (2008): 3-22.

[11] The added details to Abel's offering may lend itself to the interpretation that Cain's "an offering" (v. 3) was deemed subpar by God and the Genesis author. However, Westermann does not think so, see C. Westermann, *Genesis 1:11*, 294.

[12] Gen. 4:7. The NET Bible notes: "Sin is portrayed with animal imagery here as a beast crouching and ready to pounce (a figure of speech known as zoomorphism). An Akkadian cognate refers to a type of demon; in this case perhaps one could translate, 'Sin is the demon at the door' (see E. A. Speiser, *Genesis* [AB], 29, 32–33)." See W. Hall Harris III, ed., *The NET Bible, First Edition: A New Approach to Translation, Thoroughly Documented with 60,932 Notes* (Richardson, TX: Biblical Studies Press, 2005), note on Gen. 4:7.

[13] Jim McGuiggan as qtd. in N. Ward, *The Growth of the Seed*, 77.

and self-examination."[14] "Rather than warn Abel or his parents of the upcoming tragedy, God chooses to speak to *Cain* in what appears as an effort to prevent him from committing fratricide."[15] Reading Genesis 4 as it stands, Cain's emotions are understandable; "without reason he is disadvantaged and rejected."[16] The best hint in the text as to why Cain was rejected is found in (the very difficult) v. 7.[17] However, his next actions are unjustifiable. Cain responds to God by going to Abel, taking him out into a field alone, and killing him there.[18,19]

God comes to Cain a second time and asks, "Where is Abel your brother?"[20] Cain staunchly responds, "I do not know. Am I my brother's keeper?"[21] There has been much debate over what exactly Cain means, but it seems probable that he is declaring to be unaware of Abel's whereabouts.[22] Therefore, the sense of the response is: "I do not know where he is. I am not *responsible* for him."[23] While Cain may have thought his "secret sin" had gone unnoticed, it had not; despite Cain's lie, God, knowing the truth, responds as he did in Genesis 3:13, "What have

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[14] Franz Delitzsch as qtd. in C. Westermann, *Genesis 1-11*, 299. However, if so, then the reader must judge Cain and find his resentment as unjustified.
[15] J. Byron, "Cain's Rejected Offering," 14. Italics added.
[16] C. Westermann, *Genesis 1-11*, 298. Here I simply mean that without importing other passages into the narrative, the reader is not given many answers for God's actions. This gives the reader some sympathy for Cain, but not for long.
[17] Westermann sees vv. 6-7 as being a later addition to the narrative, "the purpose of which is to ascribe *full responsibility* to Cain for what he then does" (italics added). Westermann then suggests that it was added to deal with the possible understanding that Cain is justified in his resentful attitude. The one who added vv. 6-7, then, "explains by means of God's address that Cain alone is guilty that he went on with his deed against God's warning." See ibid., 300.
[18] Gen. 4:8a (LXX) probably reflects the better reading: "And Kain said to his brother Habel, 'Let us go through into the plain.'" See Albert Pietersma and Benjamin G. Wright, eds., "Genesis 4," in *A New English Translation of the Septuagint (Primary Texts)*, trans. Robert J. V. Hiebert (New York; Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007), 8. However, if Hamilton is right, 4:8a should be translated as, "Cain was looking for Abel his brother." If so, this understanding adds more tension to the scene. See Victor P. Hamilton, *The Book of Genesis: Chapters 1–17*, NICOT (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1990), 229-30. Westermann says, "We cannot decide whether the versions found this text before them or filled in the gap." See C. Westermann, *Genesis 1-11*, 302.
[19] Interestingly, but unlikely, A. Brock-Utne suggests that Cain was attempting to offer Abel up as a sacrifice in order to receive a blessing, since God seemingly accepted flesh offerings. See ibid., 283.
[20] Gen. 4:9.
[21] Ibid.
[22] So V. Hamilton, *Genesis 1-17*, 231.
[23] So K. A. Deurloo as qtd. in C. Westermann, *Genesis 1-11*, 304: "It is the question of responsibility that Cain rejects."

you done?"[24] Abel's blood crying out to God probably is a reference to his innocent blood demanding justice. How loud that voice must have been to God! Perhaps Cain did not hear it because he had covered his ears. Thus God must bring it directly before him. "The murderer has no escape when faced with this question because there is someone [God] who hears the victim's blood crying out…. Murder is and remains a possibility; the possibility of its success ('the perfect murder') in the sense of eliminating a human being, is thereby definitively excluded."[25]

God then curses Cain and tells him that the ground will not bear fruit for him. God, in a sense, takes Cain's life by taking away his job (his source of food) and purpose for which he had dedicated his life (see Gen. 4:2).[26] Cain is devastated and fearful for his life and begs God for mercy. In the end, the effect of sin results in both brothers crying out to God; one for justice and the other for mercy. God responds by giving him "a sign…so that no one finding him would slay him."[27] But God does not take away the consequences for his sin: banishment. After their conversation, Cain continues man's journey eastward, away from God, and lived in the land of Nod (which means, "wandering").[28] "The only curse worse than death is separation from God—Cain found himself in a literal hell on earth."[29] Despite Cain's curse and brutal treatment of his brother, he builds a city, has a family, and his lineage is extended.

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[24] Gen. 4:10. In Gen. 3:13, "What is this you have done?"
[25] C. Westermann, *Genesis 1-11*, 305.
[26] So J. Pedersen as qtd. in ibid., 307: "To be cursed is as good as losing one's life (Job 3:3)." And Westermann: "Banishment meant the confiscation of the whole basis of life and with it exposure to such danger and death as to be equivalent to surrender to death or worse" (310).
[27] Gen. 4:15. Here, Westermann does not see "the sign" as protection for Cain but rather God preventing others from intervening. He writes, "Cain, who is his brother's murderer, stands under God's curse; but no human being has the right to step in and execute God's decision…. [the sign] protects him against the intervention of anyone else." See ibid., 312-13. For more, see Westermann's excursus, pp. 312-14.
[28] So N. Ward, *The Growth of the Seed*, 81: "It seems better to understand that to *settle in Nod* means to enter a state of perpetual wandering."
[29] Ibid.

The story of Cain and Abel is referenced in the NT in Matthew 23:35 (par. Luke 11:51); Hebrews 11:4; 12:24; 1 John 3:12; and Jude 11. All of these passages point to Abel being righteous and Cain being wicked due to their respective deeds.[30]

Free Will and Moral Evil

Underlying the narrative, however, is a fundamental question: "Is Cain *really* responsible for what happened?" If the answer is, "No," then the narrative makes little to no sense. How could God, after rejecting Cain's offering, hold him responsible for his subsequent actions? Is God fair in his treatment of Cain?

There are a few things in the narrative that points to Cain exercising a *free will choice*.[31] Firstly, the author decisively puts Cain in the active role in the text: he is a farmer, an offeror, a brooder, a schemer, a killer, a liar, a backtracker, and, finally, a wanderer.[32] The author of this story could not have framed Cain in a worse light. To make matters worse for Cain, Abel in contrast is completely passive (except in his offering and cry for justice): he is the accepted one, the talked-to one, the led one, the killed one, and, finally, the one whose blood cries out for justice.[33] The author of Genesis absolves Abel of any responsibility for his death and places it all squarely on Cain. Even God acknowledges Cain's choice in the matter: "If you *do well*, will not your countenance be lifted up? And if you *do not do well*, sin is crouching at the door; and its

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[30] For discussion of how the LXX has influenced early thought on the sacrifices of the brothers, see J. Byron, "Cain's Rejected Offering," 3-7, 12-22; and Joel N. Lohr, "Righteous Abel, Wicked Cain: Genesis 4:1–16 in the Masoretic Text, the Septuagint, and the New Testament," Catholic Biblical Quarterly 71, no. 3 (2009): 485–96.

[31] According to Augustine's Free Will Theodicy, humans do not "have" free will but rather "exercise" it. "The former obtains through divine agency, the latter through human agency." See R. Douglas Geivett, "Augustine and the Problem of Evil," in *God and Evil: The Case for God in a World Filled with Pain*, ed. Chad Meister and James K. Dew Jr. (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2012), 70.

[32] Cain's "scheming nature" is more apparent in the LXX. See footnote 18 for LXX's rendering of Gen. 4:8a.

[33] Augustine argued that "no righteous act could be performed except by free choice of the will, and … God gave it for this reason," as qtd. in ibid., 70. Therefore, Abel, like Cain, demonstrates the exercising of human free will.

desire is for you, but *you must master it*."[34] God, along with the Genesis author, places Cain in the crosshairs: what Cain does next is solely his own doing. And the rest is history.

Cain's decision to kill Abel is the first instance of what is called *moral evil*. This kind of evil is produced by a moral agent. Augustine, who championed the Free Will Theodicy, believed that "evil is the corruption of a good" and thus "it is a privation in a substance."[35] "A thing is evil to the extent that it lacks some particular good that is appropriate to it."[36] According to Augustine, "evil consists in the movement of the will from immutable to transient goods."[37] Therefore, as people turn their attention away from heavenly things and towards earthly things, they are more susceptible to abusing their free will "and the result is the production of moral evil."[38] For Augustine, this truth shows that people choose to do evil and thus "the *exercise* of free will is not from God" but from oneself.[39] He sees this turn from heavenly things to earthly as an unnatural movement, thus giving the moral agent responsibility for his or her actions because "free persons are under *no necessity* to act immorally."[40] All this means, then, that while God has given humanity free will, which is therefore good because God is good, humanity has the ability to abuse it and thus corrupt God's good creation.[41]

In the story of Cain and Abel, the idea of responsibility can be seen in Cain's second conversation with God in Gen. 4:9b. Cain tells God, "Am I my brother's keeper?" As noted

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[34] Gen. 4:7. Italics added. See V. Hamilton, *Genesis 1-17*, 228: "Notice that Cain does have a choice. He is not so deeply embedded in sin, either inherited or actual, that his further sin is determined and inevitable. The emphasis here is not on Cain as a constitutional sinner, one utterly depraved, but on Cain as one who has a free choice. When facing the alternatives, he is capable of making the right choice. Otherwise, God's words to him about 'doing well' would be meaningless and comic. Should he so desire, Cain is able to overcome this creature who now confronts him. The text makes Cain's personal responsibility even more focused by its use of the initial emphatic pronoun: '*you,* you are to master it.'"

[35] R. Douglas Geivett, "Augustine and the Problem of Evil," 69-70.

[36] Ibid.

[37] Ibid.

[38] Ibid.

[39] Ibid.

[40] Ibid. Italics added.

[41] Ibid.

above, it seems that Cain's statement is rhetorical, denouncing responsibility to "keep" (or "guard") his brother. While the Hebrew words are different, it is hard to not see a connection between Abel being a "keeper" (4:2; rōʿeh, רעה) of animals and Cain's denial of being the "keeper" (4:9; šō·mēr', שׁמר) of Abel. And while we may agree with Cain in the extreme (it is not our job to be overbearing on others), we must not agree with the logical conclusion of his argument. His statement, on the surface, means, "It is not my job to have constant eyes on my brother." Fair enough. But then it becomes apparent that Cain says this, not because he is seeking to understand his proper role in relation to Abel, but because he does not care what has happened to him. He still holds Abel in contempt and has no remorse for his own actions. Therefore, to Cain, not being the "keeper" (guardian) of one's brother means to not care about him or what happens to him. Thus Cain really means, "It is not my job to protect my brother. Why should I care what happens to him?" This thought is the rationale that gives an individual "permission" to kill his or her brother.

Using Augustine's framework, the moral evil in the story can be seen not only in Cain's decision to kill his brother but throughout the entire journey Cain takes to get there. It begins with his reaction to God's decision to accept Abel's offering and not his. Cain's emotional response to the situation could have been stifled by God's warning to him, but instead he allows it to consume him. When God tells Cain he needs to master sin, Cain has a decision to make, will he allow his emotions to lead him down a dark path or will he to turn back and regain control? Cain decides to ignore God. This is evident not only in his subsequent actions but also in his lack of response to God, as portrayed by the Genesis author. According to Augustine's theodicy, Cain could have repented. He is not totally corrupted beyond repair. Augustine believed that "every

being is good insofar as it has being" and therefore evil's corruption could never be absolute.[42] However, Cain allows his emotions to develop into resentment, which grows into hatred and culminates in murder. To use Augustine's terminology: instead of "search[ing] for happiness" in "eternal things" like divine approval, "doing well" (Gen. 4:7), and pleasing God, Cain decides to search for it in "temporal things" like revenge and thus kills his brother.[43] This decision to go against God and his desire for Cain to be righteous is precisely why Cain is guilty. He heard God but did not listen to him.

But what about God's part in the story? Is God at all responsible for Cain's actions? According to Augustine, God "cannot do evil" but he can "cause evil."[44] Does he here? If we take Genesis' narrative on its own terms, it seems at first that God is the one who (inadvertently) pushes Cain over the edge. This is clear in the English translation of the story: "But for Cain and his offering He [God] had no regard. *So Cain became very angry*…."[45] It is God who accepted Abel's offering and rejected Cain's without giving clear guidelines for *how* to offer properly; it is God who questions Cain and scolds him while doing little to comfort him; it is God who "goes absent" during the crime, only to appear later to question and punish Cain. Considering Genesis on its own, Cain's emotions in the beginning make sense. Every word from God in this pericope is negatively directed at the older brother who began in v. 3 by attempting to please God with an offering. Surely God knew what Cain was going to do. How could he stand by idly?

At first glance this may seem like a fair evaluation of God, but it quickly falls apart. Firstly, there are clearly details absent from the narrative.[46] The Genesis author is not intent on

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[42] Ibid.
[43] Ibid.
[44] Ibid., 69.
[45] Gen. 4:5. Italics added.
[46] One such question: Who told Cain and Abel to sacrifice to God? And how did they know God desired it?

telling us every detail of what happened. While we are not told why God accepted one offering and rejected the other, it is apparent that God wanted *both* Abel and Cain to be accepted. If God did not care about Cain, why come to him in v. 6? It is God who initiates both conversations with Cain. It is God who presses to understand Cain better even though Cain resists. God has not stood by idly; he has come down from heaven and entered the fray. Despite God removing Man from his garden in Genesis 3, God has not removed Man from his heart. God's care for Cain is seen in vv. 6-7 and (possibly) v. 15.[47] God is shocked by Cain's actions: "What have you done!"[48] God knew what would occur, but he also knew that Cain could choose to not go through with it.[49] God did not want Cain to sin. In the end, he has no choice but to punish Cain. This punishment is the evil God causes in the story.[50] However, he still allows him to live, marry, build, and have a lineage. Therefore, blaming God for Cain's actions would be an incorrect reading of the narrative. God does not push Cain over the edge. In actuality, it is God who tries to pull him back to safety; but a man bent on falling can seldom be saved.

Conclusion

So what should we make of Genesis 4:1-16 and its relation to the problem of evil? It seems clear that the natural reading of the narrative suggests that Cain used free will to kill his brother. He did so, not because God willed it or tempted him to, but because he chose to. Cain was given

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[47] Whatever one thinks about the meaning of "the sign," it may be acceptable to say that God shows some level of mercy in not immediately ending his life. God keeps Cain from being killed by another individual. See footnote 27 above concerning the sign.

[48] I have utilized Westermann's change of God's statement from a question to forceful statement. See C. Westermann, *Genesis 1-11*, 305. He writes, "[This statement from God] expresses the perplexity which the deed must arouse in everyone."

[49] This is not a contradiction. According to Augustine, God can both know what will happen and humans still exercise free will. Augustine says, "How can it be that nothing happens otherwise than as God foreknew, if He foreknows that something is going to be willed when nothing is going to be willed?" as qtd. in R. D. Geivett, "Augustine and the Problem of Evil," 71. See pp. 70-72 for more.

[50] According to Augustine in ibid., 69: "Divine punishment of an evildoer, though experienced as evil by the one punished, is not a case of God doing evil…it can be said somewhat loosely that God causes this evil, for God exacts the punishment." For more, see larger discussion there.

every opportunity to stop, but he did not. He allowed sin to become his master, and it led to his demise. Moral evil (the evil which a person commits) in this story is framed as brother against brother. When one man supersedes another, as Abel with Cain, the lesser can become frustrated and jealous, and the result is chaos. According to Augustine, God is not the source of evil, "the free will of human persons" is. [51] Evil comes from our choices.[52] God has given mankind free will and that is a good thing.[53] However, it is up to us to decide how we are going to use it. Will we, like Cain, use it to our own destruction and that of our fellow man, or will we use it for good as God intended from the beginning? Every "individual is personally and directly responsible for the direction of his or her life."[54]

[51] Ibid., 69.
[52] Ibid.
[53] So ibid., 70: "The human will itself is created by God and is, therefore, a created good. Nevertheless, it can be abused, as it is when it is directed away from the good."
[54] Ibid.

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